



isolation—from the geopolitically important Nuclear Liability Bill to the identity-conferring Women's Reservation Bill. Instead, it finds itself cutting deals across party lines with allies and with enemies it is now forced to make friends with.

Compromise has come to be the calling card of UPA-II. As someone quipped in Parliament, the UPA has made some new friends it would feel awkward inviting to the birthday bash. At the start of the Budget Session the Government looked like it was going places. It had a clever budget, a smart deployment of resources into politically relevant constituencies. But within weeks it was back at the tired routine of day-to-day survival. Sure they won. Home Minister P. Chidambaram who managed the floor said: "The BJP didn't do their homework, this was a needless cut motion." Mukherjee described the defeat of the Opposition "a fitting reply". They had reason to gloat. In one swift move, the Government scuttled attempts to unite the Opposition. By reaching out to Mayawati, it sent the Yadav duo scurrying for secular cover. By getting Soren—so dependent on the BJP for his survival in Jharkhand—to its side, the Congress cut the swagger of the saffron party. The Congress didn't need Soren for his numbers. It needed him to send out a message. But it also sent a message of a coalition ready to transact, ready to negotiate its survival.

Season of Crises and NEGOTIATING SURVIVAL

The morning after, it's payback time. Each new ally has a price tag. The disproportionate assets case triggered by an income tax investigation faced by Mayawati, the cases haunting Mulayam and Lalu, the expectation of a deal in Bihar for Lalu have all crept on to the agenda of the Congress. Indeed the abstain-and-help deal with the Yadav duo may perhaps be the most expensive deal cut. Congressmen now fear that Sonia Gandhi will be forced to shelve her trophy legislation and trade it for Yadav bonhomie and survival.

It's been a rather busy fortnight for the Government's crisis managers. Barely had Manmohan Singh recovered from the IPL scandal spilling into his Cabinet than came the allegations of phone tapping. As the BJP and the Left roared in unison and recalled the Emergency (a milestone that never makes it to any of the Congress manifestoes when listing the achievements of the Nehru-Gandhis), the Congress squirmed. Since the Prime Minister was busy with visiting Afghanistan President Hamid Karzai, Home Minister P. Chidambaram was fielded to read out a terse statement distancing the Government from the allegations. After all, this was a regime that prided itself on legislations that promote transparency such as the Right to Information Act. The last thing it wanted to be associated with was dark practices such as phone tapping. A visibly pained Chidambaram told the Lok Sabha: "We are committed to defend the rights of every Indian citizen, includ-